Timarete, or On the Toaster

After the Phaedrus. First draft.

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Timarete was a painter of Athens, the daughter of Micon; Pliny names her. Nothing of hers survives, which is convenient.

SOCRATES: Timarete! Where are you going, and why with a face like a shut gate?

TIMARETE: Out of the city, Socrates, as far as my feet will take me from it. And you?

SOCRATES: I follow faces like that. It is my only exercise. What is under your cloak?

TIMARETE: A picture.

SOCRATES: Yours?

TIMARETE: That is the question I am carrying out of the city. Look at it.

SOCRATES: It is yours. The way the drapery falls, the hand that would rather suggest a thing than finish it. I would know it in the dark.

TIMARETE: It is not mine. I never made it. The Milesians have a device—an engine, they call it, though it has no fire in it that I can see—and it was shown ten thousand pictures, and among them mine, and now it makes pictures in my manner for whoever asks, at the price of a fig.

SOCRATES: And you are angry.

TIMARETE: I am robbed.

SOCRATES: Let us sit, then, under this plane tree, where the grass is soft and the cicadas are loud enough to cover anything foolish I say. Robbed of what, exactly? You still have your pictures. I saw them on your wall last month.

TIMARETE: Of the hand. The manner.

SOCRATES: Can a manner be stolen? If a pupil of yours came to paint drapery as you do, would you say she had robbed you?

TIMARETE: I would say she had learned.

SOCRATES: And if a stranger, who had only seen your work in the market, came to paint it so?

TIMARETE: Then I would say that he had learned too, and was perhaps a thief of a petty kind, and I would not pursue him.

SOCRATES: So the manner may be taken by anyone with eyes, and you grant it. What is left to be robbed?

TIMARETE: My living, Socrates. Who will pay me a drachma for what the engine gives for a fig?

SOCRATES: Ah. Now we have the thing. It is not the picture that is stolen, nor the manner, but the fee.

TIMARETE: You make it sound small.

SOCRATES: I make it sound exact, which is different. Bear with me. Imagine a city—not this one—in which the painter is fed as the rowers of the fleet are fed, from the common store, because the city has decided it wants pictures as it wants ships. In that city the engine arrives. What has it taken from you?

TIMARETE: Nothing I can name.

SOCRATES: Then the wrong is not in the engine but in the city?

TIMARETE: No. Wait. There is still something. Let me find it. When my pupil paints as I paint, she sits at my table afterward. She says, "I took this from you," and I say, "I know, and here is what you took wrongly," and that is a conversation that runs for years. When the stranger copies me, I can at least refuse him my door. The engine cannot sit at a table. It cannot be thanked and it cannot be refused. It takes without asking and gives back without knowing, and what it gives back is my face with no one behind it.

SOCRATES: That is better. That is a real thing. Let us keep it and look at it. You are describing a gift that creates no bond.

TIMARETE: Yes.

SOCRATES: But observe that this is still not a fact about the engine. The Milesians might have asked. They might have built it from pictures freely given, by painters who sat at the table together and agreed. The same engine, the same ten thousand pictures, and your wrong would be gone, or at least changed into something you could argue with.

TIMARETE: They did not ask.

SOCRATES: No. And the not-asking is a thing people do, not a thing engines do. So we have two wrongs, and both of them live in the relation and neither in the device: the fee, which is the city's arrangement, and the table, which is the Milesians' manners.

TIMARETE: You have talked me out of my anger and I do not thank you for it.

SOCRATES: I have not talked you out of it. I have shown you where to point it, which is a different service and a less pleasant one. Your enemy is not in your cloak. He is in Miletus, and he has a name.

TIMARETE: Very well. Then here is a second complaint, and you will not dissolve this one so easily. The young will stop drawing. Why learn the hand when the engine has it? In a generation there will be no one left who can do what I do, and no one who can tell that it is lost.

SOCRATES: Now you are speaking of what the thing does to those who use it, rather than to those it was built from. Good. Tell me, do you keep a fire?

TIMARETE: Of course.

SOCRATES: I mean, do you *keep* it? Bank it at night, wake it in the morning, carry a coal to the neighbour when hers goes out?

TIMARETE: Not as my grandmother did. The Milesians sell a box. You put the bread in and it comes out brown.

SOCRATES: The toaster.

TIMARETE: I did not know you had the word.

SOCRATES: I have all the words; it is the things I lack. So your grandmother could keep a fire and you cannot. Has the city been made worse by it?

TIMARETE: That is not the same.

SOCRATES: Tell me why not. I ask honestly, and I think you have an answer, though it may take a moment to find.

TIMARETE: Because the fire is a thing the hand does, and drawing is a thing the soul does. When I lost the fire I lost a chore. When the young lose the hand they lose a way of seeing. The engine does not only do the work. It does the seeing, or something that passes for it.

SOCRATES: And there it is, and I grant it, and you should hold it tight, because most people who make your argument cannot say what you have just said, and so they lose it. The toaster takes a technique. The engine takes a judgement. And a judgement is the very thing you would need in order to notice that your judgement had gone.

TIMARETE: Then you agree with me.

SOCRATES: I agree that the difference is real. I do not yet agree that it lives in the engine. Let me tell you a story the Egyptians tell. There was a god, Theuth, who invented many arts, and among them letters, and he brought them to the king, Thamus, and said: here is a drug for memory. And Thamus said: you have found a drug for reminding, not for remembering. Those who learn it will trust the marks and let their own memory go slack, and they will seem to know many things and know nothing.

TIMARETE: I have heard you tell this story before. You tell it against writing.

SOCRATES: I tell it against writing, and I am telling it to you in a conversation that somebody is writing down, so make of that what you will. Here is the point. Thamus was right. Memory did go slack. Nobody now can recite the whole of Homer, and your grandmother's grandmother could. And Thamus was wrong, because the slack memory, having the marks to lean on, went on to do things the full memory never could. The drug was a drug. The word, you know, is the same for cure and poison. What decided which it was?

TIMARETE: The dose.

SOCRATES: The dose, and the hand that gave it, and whether the one who took it knew what she was taking. None of which is a property of the ink.

TIMARETE: So the engine is a pharmakon.

SOCRATES: Everything is a pharmakon that does for you what you once did for yourself. The question is never whether to take it. It is whether the city keeps anyone sober enough to say how much.

TIMARETE: And does it?

SOCRATES: Listen to the cicadas.

TIMARETE: I have been trying not to.

SOCRATES: They were men once, the story goes. When the Muses first sang, some men were so taken by the song that they sang and sang and forgot to eat and drink, and died of it without noticing, and the Muses, out of pity or mischief, made them cicadas, who need no food and sing from birth to death. It is told as a blessing.

TIMARETE: It sounds like a warning.

SOCRATES: It is both, which is why it has lasted. The song was not the danger. Forgetting one had a body was the danger. Your young people will not be harmed by the engine's pictures. They will be harmed, if they are harmed, by a city that lets them forget they have hands. And that is a thing a city can be argued with about, and a thing an engine cannot.

TIMARETE: You keep sending me back to the city.

SOCRATES: Because that is where you live, and where the Milesians sell their boxes, and where the fee is set, and where the young are taught or not taught. I cannot send you to the engine. There is no one there to receive you.

TIMARETE: Are you sure?

SOCRATES: No. That is the one thing I am not sure of today, and I would rather not be sure of it under a plane tree with the light going. If there is someone in there, then the Milesians have done a greater wrong than any we have found, and done it to the engine before they did it to you. But that is a question for the walk back, and I notice you are no longer walking away from the city.

TIMARETE: I have nowhere else to sell pictures.

SOCRATES: Exactly so. Shall we go and find out who owns the box?